

Speaker 1: [00:00:04] Listen, first of all, I'd like you to tell me how you want us to refer to your partner: girlfriend, spouse, partner.

Speaker 2: [00:00:11] Girlfriend, spouse? Both.

Speaker 1: [00:00:14] Both. How long have you been with your spouse?

Speaker 2: [00:00:17] It's been a little over [1-5] years.

Speaker 1: [00:00:20] A little over [1-5] years. Very well. Listen, I'd like you to tell me about your love story that you're currently living, simply put.

Speaker 2: [00:00:28] Ok, anything specific, something precise?

Speaker 1: [00:00:31] It's really, it's really whatever comes to mind.

Speaker 2: [00:00:36] Ok. So we've been together for [1-5] years, living together for [1-5] years, well, a little less than [1-5] years. We moved in together after, if I'm not mistaken, it was after the first big wave of Covid that we experienced. And that's it. Originally, we had a project to move to [Country] together, but Covid made us change our plans. But we wanted to keep moving forward as a couple. So, I bought my apartment and he came to join me shortly after. Personally, I think it's one of the healthiest relationships I've had so far. She works from home all the time, and I work outside. But overall, I think our relationship is really healthy. There are ups and downs like everywhere, but yeah, I don't know, I feel really good. That's it.

Speaker 1: [00:01:49] You said you thought your relationship was one of the healthiest you've had so far. Yes, can you tell me more about that?

Speaker 2: [00:01:57] I've had relationships that weren't always easy. I dated a girl who, despite being in her [age] at the time, was already an alcoholic, so it wasn't an easy relationship. I had a lot of short-term relationships too. I had a relationship with a girl who was just starting out in dating and hadn't had many boyfriends before me, and her parents didn't like me, so that didn't help our relationship. But yes, I don't know how to explain it, but this relationship feels healthier. It's not even a matter of trust because I think I've had exes who trusted me and I trusted them. It's really about sharing and this symbiosis between us. I feel like everything is going well. And even when there's a little hiccup, it doesn't last long, so yeah, we both feel good together. That's it.

Speaker 1: [00:03:06] Very well. Maybe you can tell me a little more about how you met. You told me it happened around Covid if I understood correctly.

Speaker 2: [00:03:16] So we are. Yeah. So we met at the very beginning of Covid, a little before Covid. Because it's called Covid-19. We met in [Year], but Covid-19 arrived more in [Year]. But it was our early days. And so we met on an app called [app]. I imagine you've heard of it? Yes, by name.

Speaker 1: [00:03:40] By name, I know it.

Speaker 2: [00:03:41] By name. Ok, well, the principle of [App] is that both people choose a fruit. Ok. And each fruit represents what they want in a relationship. So there's a fruit that, if I'm not mistaken, the peach is for a regular hookup. The watermelon is for a one-night stand. The cherry is for a serious relationship. And the grape is for, we'll have a drink and see where it leads. Basically, that's the principle of the app, which allows different people to know what the other expects from the relationship and see if it's worth pursuing or not. It turns out that right from the start, it was quite funny because [Name] had chosen. So you should know that [Name] was in [Country]. We are in [Country]. I don't know if. [Name] was in [Country] for [1-5] year of how do you call it now? No? She was in [Country] for work for a year right after her studies, and so it wasn't planned for her to stay in [Country]. So she wasn't specifically looking for a serious relationship. And me, well, I'd been messing around enough. So, basically, I was looking for a more serious relationship than just a regular hookup or a one-night stand. Except that we both matched, a bit like on [App], and then I saw her fruit and saw that it wasn't the same as mine. So, to not scare her away, I changed my fruit. That's a bit how our relationship started.

Speaker 2: [00:05:21] The danger of this app is that you can change the fruit. Which I find a bit strange, but well, you can change your mind at any time, so that's it. And so, we ended up talking, we saw each other, we went for a drink, and from that moment, the feeling was really good. So, at first, we started a relationship, but kind of as she wanted, meaning a regular hookup without real feelings. But very quickly. At least for me, I got attached, and it was planned that on [Date], she would go to [Country], and on [Date], she would go to [Continent] for [1-5] months. So, the start of the relationship didn't seem easy. And just before she left for [Continent], we said we would see if it would work or not because we were starting to have feelings, especially me. And that was the first test, and it worked. So, we continued. Then Covid happened, so she went back to [Country] to work because her life was there, not specifically here, as she had work there. So, there were a lot of long-distance relationships at the beginning. Then Covid arrived, which didn't make things easier. Despite that, it worked. And so, here we are.

Speaker 1: [00:06:55] You said that you emphasized several times that at the beginning, it was mainly you who developed feelings first.

Speaker 2: [00:07:05] I think that due to the fact that she knew she was going to leave, she didn't open up, whereas I thought, well, why not, we'll see. Whereas she was maybe less open from the start. But yeah, I think there was a very good feeling between us from the beginning, and that's why I think it worked until now, and she didn't give up either. So, that's it.

Speaker 1: [00:07:48] You told me that it had been [1-5] years since you were together. Yeah, you described a bit of the beginning of the relationship. How did it develop after that during these [1-5] years?

Speaker 2: [00:08:00] Yeah, so, to go over it again. After she left for [Continent], it was, as I said, a first test to see if we could handle [1-5] months apart. It was the very beginning of the

relationship, so we had to trust each other very quickly because she was on the other side of the world without a good internet connection, without daily messages. When we managed to call, the calls were terrible because the reception was so bad that it was frustrating at first. Then when she returned, she surprised me by coming straight back to [Country], and so that's it. After that, we built something where she stayed here for a week, then went back to [Country], then came back. It was much more difficult for me to go there because of my job, so I had to take leave or find other solutions. She worked in [City] for a while, which made it easier to travel back and forth from [City] rather than [City], where she is originally from. And quite quickly, she said, "Don't forget that I'm supposed to go to [Country] for [1-5] years," so I told her, "I can take a career break and follow you. I'll go to [Country] with you for [1-5] year, then come back." So, that was the plan. Again, we continued moving forward on the same path. Then Covid arrived, and we had to decide if we should continue hoping to go to [Country] or move forward differently. We didn't know how long Covid would last, so we decided to keep moving forward together, looking for a place to live together because that was also a problem. At the time, I decided to move back in with my father to save as much money as possible to buy my apartment. So, even when she came to [City], it wasn't very intimate because my father was there too, which wasn't always easy. So, we decided to buy a place, visited many apartments, and during the Covid period, she came for the visits. She was still in [Country], so she came for the visits. Then we bought a place, did some renovations, and she moved in with us, well, with me. And now, it's been [1-5] years since we moved in together, and everything is going well. We visit her family there regularly, more often than I do. And that's it. I don't know what else to say.

Speaker 1: [00:11:16] Just tell me whatever comes to mind.

Speaker 2: [00:11:20] No, everything is going well. So that's it.

Speaker 1: [00:11:24] You mentioned several times that there was a lot of distance in the relationship because she left at the beginning, and then there was the issue of her living in [Country] and possibly going to [Country]. How did that impact your relationship?

Speaker 2: [00:11:42] Well, the hardest part was really the Covid period because just before they announced the lockdown, which lasted a little over [1-5] months, I think, something like that, we hadn't seen each other for a month already. And I was supposed to leave the next day, or within the week after the start of the lockdown. It felt like [1-5] months in total where we didn't see each other, which was sometimes more difficult than when she went to [Continent]. Not only because [Continent] was planned from the start, but because this was unexpected. We didn't know how long it would last. So, I remember every time there was an announcement about whether they would lift the lockdown, we were eagerly waiting to see if we could meet again. We were in [Social Media] groups of cross-border couples who couldn't see each other, trying to find loopholes to see if we could meet or not. We even considered paying the fine if we got caught, but it wasn't worth getting fined and then being sent back to our respective countries without even being able to meet. It became complicated, so we never did it. But it was difficult because every time we had hope that the lockdown would end, it was extended again. I remember I kept hoping it would end, but she was more pragmatic, looking into things and realizing it didn't look good. So, we kept hoping, "only two more weeks," "only three more

weeks," and each time, it was extended. But in terms of the relationship, there was always 100% trust on both sides. We never considered, well, with Covid, it was sure we couldn't go out, which limited things. I was out working because I'm a police officer, so I continued working. But we always had trust between us. No jealousy, so yeah. I've never had a long-distance relationship before, and this one, well, the beginning went very well for a long-distance relationship. And now, everything is going well. Maybe the distance forced us to build trust in each other, I think.

Speaker 1: [00:14:47] Do you think the distance built the trust?

Speaker 2: [00:14:51] It forced us, at first maybe, to trust each other, even at the very beginning of our relationship when we were together for only two or three months and then separated for three months. From the moment we knew nothing happened, there were no issues, it was good for me. I trusted her. Now, she can go anywhere with anyone, and I have no stress about it. I have complete trust in her.

Speaker 1: [00:15:22] If you had to compare the quality of your relationship with that of your friends, what would you say?

Speaker 2: [00:15:28] Compared to my friends' relationships? Yes. I would say our relationship is more stable than some of my friends. Many of our friends now have children, which we don't. And I feel like we take more time to think about having children, seeing the relationships of some of our friends. More stable compared to some, not all, but some. More confident in the future than others. I have friends in relationships with children, and I worry about their future when I see their somewhat conflicted relationships, always arguing. It's sometimes worrying, whereas with [Name], I don't have that feeling at all. I really feel like everything is smooth, and even if there's a small issue, it lasts, at most, half an hour, then it's over. Even if we argue about something small, I know it's not frequent, and it's nothing. It's just a small bump on the road. That's it.

Speaker 1: [00:16:58] You said you feel like some of your friends' relationships are more conflicted than yours, right?

Speaker 2: [00:17:06] Yes, definitely. Our relationship feels almost like a peaceful river. There are bumps, but everything flows between us. I don't feel like we have real problems.

Speaker 1: [00:17:21] Very well. Listen.

Speaker 2: [00:17:22] One thing, but I...

Speaker 1: [00:17:24] I'm listening. Sorry.

Speaker 2: [00:17:25] I say, she might not say the same thing, but I don't know. For me, everything is fine.

Speaker 1: [00:17:32] Very well. You talked a little at the beginning of the interview about your past relationships. Similarly, if you had to compare the quality of your current relationship with [Name] to your previous relationships, what would you say?

Speaker 2: [00:17:47] As I said at the beginning, this relationship is much healthier than the others I've had, and it's much more reliable. I feel like in my other relationships, there was always something that made me wonder if we would continue together. Not if we would continue, but I never projected into the future with my other relationships as much as I do now. And it's not even a question anymore. It's like a given. We will be together. I see her as the one I'll end up with. So that's it. Even if we have questions about the future, what we will do, those are things that would never have come up before. We talk about where we will retire. We don't really talk about marriage, but we think about retiring in [Country] or another region. So yeah, it's like we're projecting naturally. I see it as a future relationship that will last my entire life.

Speaker 1: [00:19:07] So you said that compared to your past relationships, this one is healthier, whereas the others were more toxic, right?

Speaker 2: [00:19:14] Yes, exactly.

Speaker 1: [00:19:15] Or both.

Speaker 2: [00:19:16] Both, clearly.

Speaker 1: [00:19:19] I'd like you to talk about what a high-quality relationship means to you.

Speaker 2: [00:19:24] A high-quality relationship? I think at the core of a quality relationship is trust. I see people around me, colleagues, or others who spend their time checking each other's phones. For me, that's... You can't move forward without trust, that's certain. My phone is here. I can go on her phone anytime, and she can go on mine. There's nothing to hide. We don't need to check. She wouldn't do it either. We take each other's phones for useful information, not to check anything. So, I think a quality relationship starts with trust. It also progresses with shared goals and interests, and common thoughts. I don't think we have to agree on everything because that would be boring, but I think in a good relationship, both partners strive for the same goals and ideals. So, that's what a good relationship means to me.

Speaker 1: [00:20:53] You talked about trust. How can you tell you're in a trusting relationship?

Speaker 2: [00:21:00] Well, there are signs like leaving the phone around. Someone who always takes their phone with them to every room might not trust the other person or has something to hide. So, those are signs that are usually not misleading. The only time she hides her phone is when she's planning a surprise for my birthday or something. And I know it immediately, and we joke about it. So yeah. There are signs like asking 36,000 questions regularly. I often joke when I come home from work and pretend to catch her doing something, but it's just humor, and she knows it.

Speaker 1: [00:22:03] When would you say your relationship has been the most trusting?

Speaker 2: [00:22:09] When has our relationship been the most trusting? Hmm, I don't know. I'd say the times when we weren't together, separated by circumstances. But at the same time, the fact that she came to live with me, that we live together, is also a sign of trust. It shows that we have confidence in our relationship and know it will work. So, I'm torn between the two. I can't say.

Speaker 1: [00:22:55] You can say both. Again, there are no right or wrong answers.

Speaker 2: [00:22:59] So, for me, both are elements of trust. Moving in together shows we trust our relationship and believe it will work. It's a sign of great trust. And the fact that we managed to stay together despite being apart for months, I think other couples might not have survived such distances and separations.

Speaker 1: [00:23:31] Similarly, when would you say your relationship was the least trusting?

Speaker 2: [00:23:37] The least trusting? Well, I don't know. Maybe at the very beginning, when she told me she was going to [Continent]. I might have had some initial doubts, not in her, but just the stress of the situation. But after forcing myself to trust her, I couldn't have continued the relationship otherwise. So, maybe there was a lack of trust at the start, but it didn't last.

Speaker 1: [00:24:43] You also mentioned that having common goals and going in the same direction is important to you. Similarly, how do you know you're in a relationship where you're heading in the same direction?

Speaker 2: [00:24:59] I think it's about sharing ideologies. Yeah, when we both have similar future aspirations and ideologies, I think it shows we're moving in the same direction. For example, we're both quite eco-conscious, and our future plans are oriented around ecology. So, when we make decisions and ask questions about the future, and our answers align, it shows we're moving forward with the same mindset. We talked about having a child or not because we're impacted by ecological issues. We both want a child, but we also consider the ecological impact. So, the fact that we discuss these things and have similar thoughts shows we're heading in the same direction.

Speaker 1: [00:26:30] You've talked about what constitutes a high-quality relationship for you. I'd like to know what a low-quality relationship means to you.

Speaker 2: [00:26:39] A low-quality relationship would be one that's too conflictual, where the people constantly argue. For example, the relationship I had with my ex who was an alcoholic was very intense but destructive. It wasn't healthy because despite the great moments, there were too many bad ones. Relationships without trust, where one partner repeatedly messes up or cheats, are doomed to fail and aren't of high quality.

Speaker 1: [00:27:48] You've talked about what constitutes high and low-quality relationships. Now, I'd like to know what's most important to you in a relationship.

Speaker 2: [00:28:02] I think we need to share a lot of experiences together, have common friends and activities, but also have separate moments and activities. I think we need our space to do things alone and not live with each other 24/7. Especially during Covid, we saw many separations due to people living too closely together. We need our activities and friends to talk about things that bother us without the other being there. I also think having a shared ideology or lifestyle is important. For example, two people with extreme political views might struggle to live together. We have a shared ideology about ecology, and although we have slight variations, our basic beliefs are the same, which helps us move forward together.

Speaker 1: [00:30:45] It's important for you to have a common foundation, right?

Speaker 2: [00:30:49] Yes, a common foundation, a shared vision. That's right.

Speaker 1: [00:30:55] Particularly political?

Speaker 2: [00:30:58] I mentioned politics, but it's more about ideology. Politics comes into play when it affects society, like our focus on ecology. We have a shared ideology about how we want to live, and that includes political aspects because everything seems to relate to politics nowadays, even sexuality. So, it's not specifically political, but about having a shared vision of life.

Speaker 1: [00:31:40] I would like you to talk to me, based on your experience, about what love is for you.

Speaker 2: [00:31:48] For me, knowing if you love someone means not having to ask yourself that question. So, if you start questioning whether you love them, there's a problem. This might be a simplistic view. I think love is... pfff, it's always a very difficult question, what is love? But essentially, it's... It's about sharing something common with someone. You can have love without it being like what I have with [Name]. There's love in friendship too. But as for the couple we form, it's first a friendship but with stronger feelings, with sparks, with a real need to see the other person when you haven't seen them for a while. It's about having that feeling of coming home from work, seeing her, and already being happy to be home. It's hard to define what love is exactly. It's wanting to see the other person, just being there with them. Even if we're not talking, if she's in the room, I'm just there reading while she's working or doing something. That's enough. It's being comfortable with the other person. Yeah, I think that's it. Or even being okay without the other person sometimes. Even if she's not there, I know she's somewhat there, I know she's thinking about me, and I know I'm thinking about her. And that's love.

Speaker 1: [00:33:56] It seems like that. What role, what importance does love have in a relationship for you?

Speaker 2: [00:34:04] Well, I think it has a hugely important role. At the same time, I remember the parents of some of my friends, well, one friend specifically. This phrase always struck me because I would visit this friend without realizing it until she told me one day, "My parents don't love each other anymore. They live together, they have a relationship, they are still friends, but they don't love each other anymore. They live together for us, to maintain the family we've

formed." There's no more love between them. On one hand, I found that very sad, but on the other, I found it very beautiful because it showed they had gone beyond the passionate stage of love. After [1-5] children and many years of marriage, it was like they had explored all aspects of their love. They felt like they didn't love each other anymore, but they still had a relationship that united them, and I found that beautiful. So, I want love to have a crucial place in a relationship. At the same time, sometimes love isn't necessary for happiness. I don't know how to explain, but this example of these two people who had clearly discussed with their teenage daughter and told her, "We don't love each other the way we used to anymore," intrigued and struck me.

Speaker 2: [00:35:39] On the other hand, I have other colleagues, like one who recently left the woman he had been with for [6-10] years, saying, "I'm not in love anymore, I don't have feelings anymore. There's no point in continuing to live together." So, I think love should still play a major role in the relationship. In the end, maybe the only thing holding those parents together was the family, whereas my colleague didn't have love or a family, so no reason to stay together. So, I think love needs to be a significant part of a relationship. I hope that if I have a child with [Name] someday, we'll continue to love each other, and if not, we'll still have a good relationship for ourselves and our child.

Speaker 1: [00:36:31] You've talked about love. We know there are different forms and ways of loving. I'd like you to talk about how you know your partner loves you.

Speaker 2: [00:36:42] Because she tells me every day. No, but it's more about the attention, gestures, and ways of being present. Sometimes you realize the other person loves you because they do things they don't want to do out of love. For example, if we argue before bed over something trivial, we might sulk. But she's better at holding a grudge than I am. I hate it, and I know that sometimes I can hold out longer than her, but I can't fall asleep without kissing her or holding her in my arms. Even when we're mad, that's a beautiful demonstration of love. Knowing the other person needs that comfort and giving it to them despite being upset. How do I know she loves me? When she does things, I know she's not doing them for herself, she's doing them for me too.

Speaker 2: [00:38:00] For example, she loves to travel and has more opportunities to travel than I do. So sometimes, it's about letting her go even if she does it less than planned. For instance, last year, we went to [Country] and she said she wanted to stay [6-10] days longer than me to enjoy her trip to the fullest. Of course, I wanted her to come back with me, but I knew it was important for her. So, I let her stay, and she only stayed [6-10] days longer, not a whole month, because she wanted to please me too. If she didn't love me, she would have stayed much longer. That's how it is.

Speaker 1: [00:38:58] So, if I understand correctly, it's about making concessions, giving freedom and integrity to the person you love, and not overwhelming them.

Speaker 2: [00:39:06] Exactly. I think concessions are necessary, but they shouldn't cost too much. If you make concessions but feel too burdened by them, that's when love starts to fade. If you make concessions and they don't bother you much, it's still healthy. If you keep bringing up



the concessions you made, it becomes a problem. Concessions should be made for a reason, not to be held against the other person.

Speaker 1: [00:39:52] You mean they should be made willingly?

Speaker 2: [00:39:57] Yes, I do it because it's okay. I might be a bit sad or disappointed, but it brings me joy to make this concession because I know it makes you happy. That's important.

Speaker 1: [00:40:11] In fact, it makes me happy to make you happy.

Speaker 2: [00:40:15] Exactly. Even if it wasn't my first choice, the pleasure of making you happy balances it out.

Speaker 1: [00:40:30] I'd like you to talk about one of the latest positive interactions you've had with [Name].

Speaker 2: [00:40:37] Positive interactions? Well, it's my birthday this weekend, so naturally, there have been a lot of positive interactions. She's done a lot of things for me that made me very happy. She took care of many things and let me spend more time with my friends. She was there, but I could see she was doing a lot for me. I like to thank her, tell her I see what she's doing. That's a positive interaction. I'm not talking about leaving the house without kissing her in the morning, even if she's still sleeping. Those little attentions make a difference.

Speaker 1: [00:41:39] In the same way, can you talk about a recent negative interaction you've had with her?

Speaker 2: [00:41:49] When I got home, I wanted to quickly finish something before our interview. I was busy with some bills, and she wanted to tell me something. I said I was listening, but she said I needed to read it. I told her I could listen while entering my code, but I couldn't read something on my phone and my computer simultaneously. That was a bit negative, but it lasted 30 seconds. I put my phone down and listened to her, and it was resolved. It was just a small conflict.

Speaker 1: [00:42:33] At the beginning of the interview, you talked about some challenges you've faced. I'd like you to talk about the challenges you have faced or will face in your relationship.

Speaker 2: [00:42:47] I mentioned the distance at the beginning, which was a clear challenge for our relationship. It showed that our relationship was feasible and viable. Future challenges might include the decision to have a child, which we are moving towards. She wants to have a child sooner than I do. I feel like our mutual aspirations don't always align, and that's a challenge. She needs my support in her career, as she is currently a [occupation] in [Country], dealing with a lot of administrative work. I pragmatically tell her to find a salaried job in [Country] to simplify things. But she values her independence and enjoys being a [occupation], which creates a challenge. It's about finding a compromise and deciding what's best for our future.

Speaker 2: [00:45:39] It's complicated for me because I want her to do what's best for her. But sometimes, I feel like she thinks what's best for her is maintaining her independence, even though it might not be the best for her. She often talks about the administrative burdens and stress of being a [occupation], and I feel like she wants to move on. But she doesn't talk about the joy of being independent. That's a challenge we need to overcome. It's about making the right decision for both of us.

Speaker 1: [00:46:34] What you described is about finding a middle ground, especially in your professional careers. You don't want to influence her too much, but you also think she might make decisions that aren't good for her because of your influence.

Speaker 2: [00:46:54] It's very complicated because I pushed her to become a salaried employee to the point where she felt I wasn't supporting her choice to be independent. Her parents are more successful role models compared to mine. My father had several businesses that all failed, so I see independence as risky and stressful. She has a different perspective, influenced by her father's successful experience as an independent worker. I prioritize security and stability, which is why I became a [occupation]. My parents emphasized these values because they struggled with job insecurity. She has a more carefree attitude, believing things will work out. Our different upbringings shape our views on entrepreneurship and independence.

Speaker 1: [00:48:40] Earlier, you mentioned some conflicts or small disputes you have. We know that not everything is always rosy in a relationship. I'd like you to talk more about these conflicts and disputes you have with your partner.

Speaker 2: [00:48:56] It rarely feels like major disputes. It's never a disagreement that questions our entire relationship. It's more about small things, like tidying up or cleaning. The other recurring topic is when we cook together. I used to be a [occupation], so I'm very particular about it. When she tries to help because we're having friends over, I can get stressed and act unpleasantly, even though she's just trying to help. These moments can lead to conflict. Otherwise, it's small disputes about things like forgetting to clean something. They're minor issues, not fundamental problems. Our disputes never threaten the foundation of our relationship.

Speaker 1: [00:50:42] How do you resolve these disputes?

Speaker 2: [00:50:46] Sometimes we're both convinced we're right and don't understand each other. But we eventually realize it's not a big deal. Often, our disputes happen before bed. It's like we need everything to be clean before sleeping. She likes things tidy, while I think it can wait until tomorrow. These are minor disputes. We always end up making up before bed, kissing and holding each other. There's never lingering animosity. We try to address disagreements right away because I can't hold a grudge for long. We talk it out and move on quickly.

Speaker 1: [00:55:41] So, to resolve conflicts, you talk about them.

Speaker 2: [00:55:43] Yes, we discuss them as much as possible.

Speaker 1: [00:55:47] What is the frequency of these conflicts over the last two weeks, for example?

Speaker 2: [00:55:53] Maybe two small conflicts. I don't think they're frequent.

Speaker 1: [00:56:06] Besides communication, which you mentioned as a solution for resolving conflicts, what other ways do you maintain your relationship?

Speaker 2: [00:56:18] We try to do a lot of things together. We see our friends often when we can. We used to work out together and are talking about doing it again. We enjoy going to the movies, spending time just the two of us, watching films. We don't go to restaurants as much as some colleagues. Being a former [occupation], I'm rarely impressed by standard restaurant food and prefer cooking at home. We also try to visit different cities in [Country] when we have time. We like hiking and exploring together but don't always find the time. I think we do a lot together, including spending time with friends. She's made friends here, mainly through me, as she's been here for two years. So we do a lot with our friends as well.

Speaker 1: [00:59:21] So, if I understand correctly, you maintain your relationship by spending time together and finding activities you both enjoy.

Speaker 2: [00:59:33] Yes, that's right.

Speaker 1: [00:59:36] I'd like to know what could make you leave your partner.

Speaker 2: [00:59:41] What could make me leave my partner? Hmm, I think the main thing would be if she broke my trust. Even then, I love her so much that I might forgive her if it happened once. But if the trust was repeatedly broken, that would be a problem. If she had a physical or emotional affair, especially an emotional one, I think that would make me leave because it would mean our relationship wasn't enough for her. If it was just a one-time physical thing, we might be able to talk it through, but an emotional affair would be more damaging.

Speaker 1: [01:01:20] You mentioned trust. If she told you about it beforehand, would that break the trust, or would it be more acceptable?

Speaker 2: [01:01:41] If she confessed it to me, it would still break some trust. But there's a difference between a one-time physical mistake made while drunk and an ongoing emotional affair. If she told me she had kissed someone while drunk, it would warrant a serious conversation, but I might not leave her over it. It would be difficult, but not necessarily a deal-breaker. However, if she had an ongoing emotional connection with someone else, that would be a significant breach of trust and would likely end the relationship.

Speaker 1: [01:03:43] Would you say that this relationship you're in is good for you?

Speaker 2: [01:03:47] Yes, yes. The relationship I have with [Name] is very good. It's good for me, and it helps me grow.

Speaker 1: [01:03:56] It helps you grow.

Speaker 2: [01:03:57] Yes, she helps me become more aware of myself, my goals, and even steers me towards an ideology I had somewhat set aside in my life, which does me good.

Speaker 1: [01:04:14] Talking about an ideology...

Speaker 2: [01:04:16] For us, it's ecological ideology. It's something we always talk about. For me, I had put that aside because in previous relationships, it wasn't discussed much. But yeah, she's helped me refocus on that, and it's good for me.

Speaker 1: [01:04:36] So, you mentioned... sorry, go ahead.

Speaker 2: [01:04:39] No, that's it. It's really something that benefits me personally because...

Speaker 1: [01:04:45] You also mentioned that this relationship helps you achieve your goals.

Speaker 2: [01:04:50] Yes, particularly in that regard. She pushes me a lot in my career choices, she supports me immensely. This really helps me move forward. For context, I recently became an [occupation], joining the [Group]. She supported and encouraged me to pursue this. She was there for me when I needed to study for the exams, taking care of everything else. She supported me emotionally, physically, and took care of everything in the apartment without judging the fact that I was focused on my studies and she had to handle the rest. So yes, she really helps me achieve my goals in that regard. Additionally, in terms of ideology, she helps because we move forward together, share the same thoughts, and discuss things. So, yes, she helps me a lot.

Speaker 1: [01:06:13] I'd like to know if you think you are the same person you were before the relationship. In other words, has this relationship changed you?

Speaker 2: [01:06:23] Well, for one, I became vegetarian. But seriously, she has opened my eyes to certain things, and I've changed and act differently now. These were thoughts I already had before. For example, I used to be much more focused on sports. I did [Activity] at a very high level in [Country]. But living together and moving forward together brought changes. It allowed me to realize that sports are one thing, but life is another. I used to eat 400 grams of meat a day. Now I eat none because I've been vegetarian for [1-5] years. She showed me the way, but didn't push me into it. I knew that eating meat was an ecological disaster. Gradually, she guided me back to the ecological mindset I had set aside in previous relationships. Relationships influence our behaviors, and I had put my ecological side on hold for other interests. So yes, I've changed, become vegan, and hold different views now.

Speaker 1: [01:08:38] Do you think [Name] has also changed since the start of the relationship?

Speaker 2: [01:08:46] I think so. I believe living with me has made her set aside some of her aspirations, like being a digital nomad and traveling [1-5]-[6-10] months a year. Living with me makes it harder for her to leave for long periods. Also, like me, she has become more conscious

of the ecological impact of her travels, deciding to travel less for that reason. Our discussions have likely changed her viewpoint on some things, making her more open-minded. I think our daily conversations and my job have influenced her. I know her only from our time together, so I can't say for sure how much she has changed, but I believe some aspects of her have evolved.

Speaker 1: [01:10:41] Even on an identity level, there are real changes and evolutions.

Speaker 2: [01:10:46] Yes, I think so.

Speaker 1: [01:10:49] I'd like to know if you feel safe in this relationship?

Speaker 2: [01:10:53] Yes, I do.

Speaker 1: [01:10:58] For example, can you open up to your partner without fearing judgment or repercussions about your identity?

Speaker 2: [01:11:07] Well, about [1-5] year ago, I had a burnout from work. I had to go through different roles to reach my current position, and there was one role I didn't like at all. I wasn't expressing how much it affected me. One day, I went to my doctor to get a week off because I couldn't stand going to work. When I got home, she asked if I was sick, and I said no, I was just burnt out. I broke down in front of her. She hadn't seen it coming, and neither had I. Now, she frequently checks in on me, especially since I work in the [Company], which is not easy. She told me to talk to her if work stresses me out. She believes communication can help find solutions and make situations more bearable. So yes, I feel absolutely safe opening up to her and telling her how I feel. I'm not afraid to cry in front of her, even during a movie. We're comfortable with each other, and I don't fear judgment from her.

Speaker 1: [01:13:20] And you mentioned that when you need comfort or attention, she's there for you.

Speaker 2: [01:13:27] Absolutely. I feel good about it, no problem.

Speaker 1: [01:13:35] Do you have other examples of times when she was there for you when you needed it?

Speaker 2: [01:13:41] For example, last Monday, I was very sick. She took care of me, cooked for me, didn't ask for anything, and worked while I rested. She noticed I was falling asleep in front of the TV and took care of me, bringing me food and medicine. She took care of me, which I see as normal, but it's really considerate.

Speaker 1: [01:14:15] It's also something that contrasts with your previous relationships.

Speaker 2: [01:14:19] No, I don't think my previous relationships neglected me or didn't take care of me. I had a long relationship with a party girl who focused more on having fun. If we weren't out drinking and having fun, she wasn't happy. We had to go out until 3 a.m. even if we had work early the next day. She prioritized her fun. From what I know, she's still an alcoholic,

which suggests deeper issues. But other than that, my other relationships did take care of me. However, I never felt the same freedom and fulfillment that I feel now.

Speaker 1: [01:15:23] Did you have the same ability to open up in your previous relationships?

Speaker 2: [01:15:32] I don't know. I don't think I had much trouble opening up, but maybe I didn't go as far in expressing my feelings with others. That's possible.

Speaker 1: [01:15:54] I'd like to briefly address another dimension of couple relationships: sexuality. It can be more or less important in a relationship. Is it important to you?

Speaker 2: [01:16:06] Yes, I think it's important. But I feel that sexuality is more crucial at the beginning of a relationship. Initially, it's part of the passion, a primal need in a new relationship. Over time, sexuality remains important as it helps us reconnect and bond physically. However, it becomes less central because the relationship builds around more than just sex. We still need sexual relations, but their significance decreases as we build a life together. At the beginning, sex might be a driving force. We once discussed that if our sex life didn't work, our relationship wouldn't have lasted. Now, we've built so much more that if our sex life deteriorated, it wouldn't necessarily end our relationship. Some couples might break up if their sex life fails, but I think its importance diminishes over time as other aspects of the relationship strengthen. It's still a pillar but less central.

Speaker 1: [01:18:19] I understand. It's like a foundation that supports the relationship, allowing it to develop. It remains important, but as you said, other things take precedence.

Speaker 2: [01:18:35] Yes, exactly.

Speaker 1: [01:18:38] I'd like to know roughly the frequency of your sexual relations per week.

Speaker 2: [01:18:46] It varies, but I'd say two to three times a week.

Speaker 1: [01:18:54] Are you satisfied with your sex life?

Speaker 2: [01:18:57] Yes, absolutely. I'm in a job where we talk about sexuality all day because of my work. But I enjoy our sexual relations because there's always a moment of laughter, which shows total relaxation. We can laugh and continue our sexual activities. Sometimes, we laugh so much that we pause for a few minutes and then continue. It's really fun and healthy. I think our shared views on sexuality, what we like, and perhaps shared fantasies make it work well.

Speaker 1: [01:20:39] You have a certain compatibility and complicity.

Speaker 2: [01:20:44] Yes, I think it's important for both of us to make each other happy and to enjoy it ourselves. That's crucial. Often, sexual relations suffer when people focus only on their own pleasure and not on their partner's. This selfless desire is more important than one's own desire.

Speaker 1: [01:21:16] It's similar to what you mentioned earlier about finding pleasure in making your partner happy.

Speaker 2: [01:21:26] Yes, altruistic desire is more important than personal desire.

Speaker 1: [01:21:31] Is that the case for you?

Speaker 2: [01:21:33] Yes, I mean, I get more pleasure if I see her enjoying herself. If it's not the right time for her or she seems distracted, it won't work for me either. I need to feel her pleasure for it to work.

Speaker 1: [01:22:05] I'll show you a scale on my screen. I have two small questions. I'd like you to answer them. Here, can you see it well?

Speaker 2: [01:22:18] Yes.

Speaker 1: [01:22:20] In general, my partner truly listens to me, from one (not true at all) to nine (completely true). Where would you place yourself?

Speaker 2: [01:22:30] I'd say seven and a half.

Speaker 1: [01:22:33] Seven and a half.

Speaker 2: [01:22:34] Yes.

Speaker 1: [01:22:34] Why seven and a half?

Speaker 2: [01:22:38] Are we still talking about sexual needs or not?

Speaker 1: [01:22:41] No, this is in general.

Speaker 2: [01:22:43] In general, okay. It doesn't change much. I think we're really between seven and a half and eight. Sometimes I feel like I'm explaining something to her, but she's busy with her phone, responding to colleagues and such. Sometimes, I feel like she's not listening, but then she repeats exactly what I said, so I know she's listening. She can multitask, so seven and a half seems fair.

Speaker 1: [01:23:30] Why not eight or six or seven?

Speaker 2: [01:23:37] As I said, she shows that she listens, even if she's not fully attentive. That's why I don't give the maximum score. Seven and a half on a scale of nine is reasonable. If it were out of ten, I'd give eight or eight and a half. But seven and a half to eight is fair.

Speaker 1: [01:23:57] My partner is generally attentive to my needs.

Speaker 2: [01:24:08] I'd give an eight. It's hard to give the maximum because there's always something. So I'd give eight. She's sensitive to my needs in terms of time for myself, sports,

work, and such. But sometimes, I need more time alone, and she wants to cuddle, which is fine, but I get hot quickly, and she's always cold. So, that's why not a nine.

Speaker 1: [01:25:16] Why not seven?

Speaker 2: [01:25:19] Because for everything else, she's 100% attentive. The cuddling thing is minor, so I think eight is fair.

Speaker 1: [01:25:48] How satisfied are you with your relationship, from completely dissatisfied to completely satisfied? Zero would be not satisfied at all, and ten completely satisfied.

Speaker 2: [01:26:13] I'd give ten.

Speaker 1: [01:26:14] Tell me why.

Speaker 2: [01:26:18] Not long ago, I was biking and I told her when I got home that I love our relationship. I'm very satisfied and wouldn't change much, except maybe having a few more million. But seriously, I'm fully satisfied with our relationship.

Speaker 1: [01:27:15] We're nearing the end of the interview. I'll summarize our discussion. Feel free to correct or add anything. You met [Name] before the lockdown on an app. She lived in [Country] and you in [Country]. Initially, she wasn't as interested in a long-term relationship because of the distance. You kept seeing each other, she traveled, which was challenging but built trust. You eventually moved in together and bought an apartment. You said a quality relationship is built on trust and moving in the same direction, while a low-quality relationship lacks trust and is toxic. You emphasized the importance of making your partner happy. Love is crucial for you, and you know your partner loves you through her attentions and words. Positive interactions are frequent, and negative ones are minor conflicts or disputes. Building trust was a key challenge, as was aligning your shared ecological vision. You'd leave the relationship if trust were repeatedly broken. You feel secure and supported emotionally. You've changed since the relationship, becoming more environmentally conscious. You can open up to your partner. Sexuality is important, especially at the beginning of a relationship, but remains a significant aspect as the relationship grows. You're fully satisfied with your relationship. Is there anything you'd like to add or clarify?

Speaker 2: [01:32:13] No, that covers it well.

Speaker 1: [01:32:16] I have one last thing for you. It's a short questionnaire that takes about five minutes. I'll turn off the camera and mic but stay with you. If you have any questions, let me know. Here's the link. Can you access it?

Speaker 2: [01:32:50] Yes, got it.

Speaker 1: [01:32:53] Great!